

BIODIVERSITY

* The term Biodiversity refers to the variety and variability among living organisms and the ecological complexes in which they occur.

* Biodiversity can be defined as 'the totality of genes, species and ecosystems of a region'.

Threats to the biodiversity.

Human activities are the major threat to biodiversity. The important factors leading to the extinction of species and consequent loss of biodiversity are described below.

* Destruction of Habitat

- Destruction of natural habitat is the primary threat to the biodiversity.
- Natural habitats which protect natural flora and fauna are being converted to human settlements.
- Deforestation deprive animals of food and shelter.
- Migratory animals are also affected by deforestation due to disturbance in their routes.
- Dams are blocking, spawning and migration of fishes.

* Habitat Fragmentation.

- Habitats that formerly occupied wide areas are more often ~~divided~~ divided into pieces by roads, fields, towns, canals, powerlines etc.
- This is the process by which a large, continuous area of habitat is divided into two or more fragments.
- This may limit the dispersal and colonisation potential of species and also reduces the foraging ability of species.

* Disturbance and Pollution.

- Natural as well as man made disasters such as fire, tree fall etc. ~~aff~~ affect communities adversely.

Eg. Massive use of synthetic products and vast release of radiation and spillages of oil in sea lead to change in habitat quality.

* Hunting and Overexploitation.

- Man started hunting wild animals for food, safety and pleasure.

Disappearance of Dodo and of cheetah is due to massive hunting.

Overfishing ^{is} seriously depleting the marine and fresh water living resources.

* Poaching.

- Killing of prohibited wild animals for illegal trade is poaching.

Despite international ban on trade in products from endangered species, smuggling of wildlife items like fur, horns, tusks, live specimens for millions are still going on.

CHILD LABOUR

* The International Labour Organization (ILO) has estimated that, in developing countries, 250 million children in 5-14 age group work for wages.

* Most working children are found in agriculture; urban children work as domestic help or in trade and services, with fewer in manufacturing and construction.

* Most childworkers are denied education and a normal childhood.

- Some are confined and beaten or reduced to slavery.

- Others are denied to go home or leave the work place.

* The worst form of child labour occurs when a family hands a child over to an employer in return for a small, but urgently needed, loan.

- In most cases child cannot work off debt, nor can family raise enough money to buy the child back.

* There have been an international public awareness of the high incidence of child servitude in the carpet industry of South Asia.

* India has the largest number of working children in the world, the estimate ranging between 60 and 115 million.

- Most of them work in agriculture, while rest pick bags, make bricks, ~~pot~~ polish, gem stones.

* In December 1996, the Supreme Court of India issued a ground breaking decision and detailed framework for ~~pen~~ punishing employers of children in hazardous competition.

* WHRC began appointing special officers who applied pressure in certain regions and industries.

POPULATION EXPLOSION.

* Population explosion refers to the number of people that live in an area. It is a major issue for developing countries.

* It refers to the rapid increase in population of an area among human beings. Furthermore, it is a situation where economy is not capable of coping with the increasing demand of its population.

Causes of Population Explosion.

* Increase in the birth rate:-

Due to lack of control on delivery and unawareness of people the birth rate is increasing rapidly. Furthermore, the birth rate has increased many folds in comparison to the death rates.

* A decrease in infant mortality rate.

Earlier life expectancy was 55-60 years, but now due to better and improved medical facilities, the life expectancy increased to 70-75 years.

* High level of illiteracy.

The literacy level of women is one of the biggest problems of family planning.

Population Growth rate curve.

